

KF33 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

In this lesson we will introduce the **Lectio Divina** meditation. **Lectio Divina**, or *divine reading*, is a traditional Benedictine practice of meditation and prayer. Its purpose is to help us personalize Scripture and deepen our communion with God. There are four steps in the **Lectio Divina**. First, we read a passage from the Bible several times. We then meditate, opening our minds to what the Holy Spirit might be saying to us through the passage. Next, we respond to any impression that we receive. Finally, we contemplate, or maintain our awareness, of what we have experienced. There are no right or wrong responses to the passage. **Lectio Divina** is an entirely personal experience.

Lectio Divina

Take a meditation posture, with the crown of your head reaching toward the heavens and your tailbone reaching toward the earth. Allow your body to hang from the central pole of your spine. Scan your body for tension, and relax. Breathe. You might use the word *CALM* to center yourself for one minute. (*Pause for 1 minute*)

1. Read the passage

I will read a short text from the Bible and then pause. You may wish to focus your mind by repeating the Scripture to yourself. Observe as you allow the words to rise and fall with your breath. The text for this meditation is from John 17:1.

*Glorify your Son so that your Son may also glorify You.
(Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

2. Receive as you listen

Relax while I read this sentence three times, pausing for thirty seconds between readings. Take the attitude of a listener and observe your experience. In the stillness between the readings, allow a feeling, thought, or image to come to mind that may be related to the words. If nothing comes to mind, notice the absence of thought or just enjoy the stillness. Compassionately notice any other feelings or thoughts that may intrude, and then return to the text. Let's begin.

*Glorify Your Son so that Your Son may also glorify You.
(Read 3 times, pausing for 30 seconds after each reading)*

3. Respond

If you were aware of an impression, an understanding, or a feeling as you listened to the words, respond to God with affirmation and gratitude. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

4. Rest in awareness

Now rest in stillness for one minute as you hold in your awareness whatever has happened during this time. You might allow the Scripture to gently recede, and then focus your mind on your breath. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Pause, and re-engage with your environment. You may wish to take this next minute to record your experience in your KF journal or on your **Meeting Preparation Guide**, or you may wish to rest and return to your breathing. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

This month we will begin to explore KF Confession 8:

We co-labor with the Creator to seek and to save that which was lost.

Consider for a moment what people in the ancient world had to do to recover a kidnapped loved one. To achieve their goal, these people needed developed courage, resources, and skills; they needed to face realities; and they needed endurance. You are engaged in the same process, but you are not alone. The God who created you is working with you to seek and to save the person that you have lost. That person is your True Self.

Quiet self-confidence, peaceful self-management, and mindful generosity are trustworthy indicators that you have found your True Self. In KF we are looking to see progress in these areas, not perfection. Once you have experienced living in your True Self, you will want to guard the life of that self and nurture its glorious potential.

Do you remember that early in our KF training we identified our three greatest fears? We saw how these fears undermine the efforts we make to recover our True Self. We also learned that there are three categories of fear. First, we might fear ourselves. We are afraid that we are crazy, worthless, or vulnerable and will fail to meet our standards, so we are harsh with ourselves and try to force a certain performance. In those areas where we fear ourselves, we are full of self-doubt, and in our self-hate we judge every choice we make. We then try to avoid facing what we fear about ourselves by imposing on others, convincing people of our value, and forcing life and others to do things our way. Or we choose chronic inertia to confine our minds and our behavior and to avoid exposure to situations that might reveal what we fear about ourselves. Second, we might fear others. What others think and do terrifies us, and in order to feel safe we compulsively control or avoid them. We are continually vigilant, watching for people's

reactions, imagining their motivations, judging their choices, and performing in ways that we hope will get the reaction we think we need. Third, we might fear loss—loss of our self-image or reputation, loss of support from others, loss of money, loss of our time or personal space, and loss of self-control. We might fear missing out on life. Fear of loss expresses itself in egocentric greed, possessiveness, withdrawing support, and hoarding of any kind. It is also revealed in our rigid and pervasive claims. The fear of loss is the cause of a multitude of anxieties about our well-being: we fear the future; we fear changing relationships; and we fear any threat to our search for idealized glory.

You can probably sense right now what a huge amount of energy it takes to live in fear—energy that could be used to seek and save your True Self. If you are full of fear, it will take all the energy you have just to manage that fear and keep you functioning. Think about your fear. What are you afraid of losing—your self-value, your reputation, or missing out on the delights of this world? *You may be discovering that you are more motivated by your fear of loss than by your love. (Repeat)*

We now know that the True Self is not motivated by misoriented fear. It is not afraid of itself, of the Idol's self-hate, or of going into the not-knowing. It is not motivated by the fear of what others might think or do, nor is it motivated by the fear of loss. When you feel strong emotions or craving, ask yourself: *What am I afraid of losing? (Repeat)* If you are afraid of losing something, you might tell God about that. Use your tools and ask Him to calm your fear. Courageously tell Him that you are willing to lose whatever it is for His sake. Let go, and see what God can do.

I want to remind you, however, that God will not always act according to your hopes and plans. He will act in the interest of your True Self. Letting go with no strings attached is evidence of your trust in God's purposes and love. Sometimes I feel virtuous about letting something go and am then tempted to start making claims on God as if He owed me something in return. I often do not know that I have made a claim until the feeling of disappointment or unfairness flags the presence of an unfulfilled claim. When God reveals a claim, it is a great gift! God is seeking our True Self. He doesn't make deals with Idols.

It takes courage to act in an oriented manner no matter how much fear we feel. You might recall our KF motto: *Train hard. Fight easy.*¹ *(Repeat)* Just as soldiers are trained to act in a disciplined manner in the face of fear, members of Karis Fellowships are trained to move through the fear into self-disciplined action. We start by training our courage. You may have read and heard that courage is the foundation of all virtue. Let me repeat that: courage is the foundation of all virtue.² Without courage in the face of life's experiments, you will not take the steps that lead to real virtue, moral integrity, and principled choices. Without courage, you will find yourself retreating into old patterns of behavior, and you will justify your choices with virtue stories that restore your pride and mask your fears; and when you are faced with the challenges and enticements of this material world, the compulsion to save your life will overwhelm your best intentions.

Every time you exercise your courage and make an oriented choice in the face of fear, your courage grows. This is called training. Then, when you have to bear the heavy weight of distress or success, or you need to take the next step in your journey toward healing, you will have the courageous muscle to stand your ground no matter what your Idol Self is screaming at you. When your mission requires you to take risks, to assert your real power and influence, or to let go, you will be able to remain oriented because you have been training hard.

You might consider this: *Your fear of loss may be just a shadow of the horror and grief that you unconsciously feel over a much more profound loss, the loss of your True Self. (Repeat)*

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father, for Your sake, I want to give up my search for glory and seek my True Self. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?”)

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

In this lesson, we will continue to look at the letter from James. James has already pointed out how the man-made legal systems in the market economy create partiality in our relationships. In chapter 2, James presents partiality in terms of showing deference to the wealthy and contempt to the poor. In the market economy, we believe that showing deference to the wealthy person may be a worthwhile investment, whereas being generous to a poor person seems like a waste of resources. James is trying to persuade us to shift our thinking about personal relationships so that we can move out of the cause and effect of the market economy and into the cause and effect of the karis economy. Both economies are valid ways to circulate in this material world. The market economy is based on law and contracts, so there is an agreed protocol of exchange between parties. It is the economy of money, skills, property, and horse trading. The karis economy, on the other hand, is based on mutual yet unpredictable generosity. It is the most productive way to engage in personal relationships and to build a trusting and trustworthy community. Furthermore, karis is the only way to relate to God through the True Self.

I would like you to think about the problem of partiality in the community as a metaphor for how we favor the Idol Self over the True Self. Think of the Idol Self as the rich or valued person and the True Self as the poor or despised person. The first has been fed and watered with our available resources, perhaps for decades, and the other has lived on the fringe, scrounging for scraps of leftover energy. In its colossal egocentricity, the Idol is invariably partial to itself, exclusively favoring its own compulsive needs and never being authentically generous toward others. Partiality in favor of the Idol Self is the worst kind of partiality. The mirror that James refers to in the first chapter of his letter reveals whether we are doers or just hearers of the logos.³ If we look into this mirror with partiality, choosing to see what we want to see about ourselves, we will only see the mask of the Idol which hides the evidence of our misorientation. On the other hand, if we are looking into the mirror to discover the truth about ourselves, we will recognize what our True Self needs in order to grow into its true potential—and we will recognize what others need in order to grow into theirs.

In the second chapter of his letter, James writes about faith. To give us a better understanding of what James is teaching us, I have introduced other accurate and valid translations of the Greek word for faith, including *trust*, *believe*, and *a set of beliefs*.

Let’s listen now to my paraphrase of **James 2:10–23**.

¹⁰If you try to use the law of your Idol’s system and then fail in one area of your law, you will condemn everything about yourself. ¹¹The same Lawgiver who says, “Do not be sexually untrustworthy,” also says, “Do not be murderous.” In other words, if you choose to live by law and be chaste, but are still murderous, you make yourself fail the whole law.

¹²Instead, speak and also act like citizens who are brought to court by the law of freedom

rather than like slaves who are brought to court by the law of the Idol. ¹³The resulting verdict of the court according to the Idol's law will be inexorable for those who are inexorable for they cannot help but punish themselves and others through self-hate. Mercy, however, exults and is self-confident in trials. Mismanaged self-hate throws us back into slavery, but having mercy on ourselves and on others is the new way to handle mistakes and invite possibilities. Mercy is real self-confidence in action.

¹⁴How does it benefit you, or anyone, if you say that you believe but do not act on what you believe? Your belief will not rescue you or anyone else. ¹⁵And that lack of congruence between your beliefs and actions will be exposed when you encounter a member in the community who is in need. ¹⁶For example, you say to someone in need, "Go away from me in peace with my blessing of warmth and food," but you do nothing practical about their need. Their need is stirring up conflicts in you, and since you won't deal with your own inner conflict about showing mercy to yourself, you refuse to deal with any conflict about mercy. ¹⁷In this way, relying on a set of beliefs without taking action destroys your faith's vitality. ¹⁸Look at it this way. You say that you trust God, or have a set of beliefs that you trust, but I take action. Show me your trust apart from action, and I will show you my trust by my action. Which is more real? ¹⁹You say that you believe that God is undivided in His person and in His activities, and that is admirable, but even demons believe that. Unlike you, however, who separate faith from action, demons are congruently afraid of God. ²⁰You vain and pretentious people, are you willing to recognize that your faith separated from your action is not doing its job? It is not preparing your soil for seeds of orientation. ²¹Abraham, who was our first example of a person living in a relationship with God based on faith, was oriented through his action—the action of taking Isaac, his son, up to the place of sacrifice. In the same way, you are learning to sacrifice your dreams of an idealized glory. ²²You can see that his action was congruent with his faith, and through his action his faith reached its fulfillment. That fulfillment was orientation to God. Abraham's gift to God in his relationship was his effort, not his set of beliefs. ²³And what is written was fulfilled: "Abraham was trustworthy with God, responding to God with his karis gift, and this act—this offering—was credited to Abraham as orientation, and he was called the beloved friend of God."

Take a deep breath.

Let's look at a few points that James presents in this passage.

1. The law cannot rescue you

You cannot rescue the True Self by imposing legal systems and judging what is right or wrong according to your own standards. It is impossible to fulfill all the requirements of a legal system, and if you try, you will always be in danger of self-condemnation. When we are judging others for their choices, which are often driven by their cravings, we might look at how viciously we judge our own cravings and choices. Perhaps the cravings of others frighten us because we are frightened by our own crazy cravings. Cravings are part of the Idol system—and we use all kinds of stories to justify our cravings without considering that they are often symptoms of the Idol's compelling need to relieve anxiety.

No matter how many times you have kept the law, the justice of a civil court condemns your whole person if you commit murder or rape. The "justice" of the Idol system is even more severe. No matter

how many times you fulfill its demands, the Idol condemns your whole self for the slightest infringement of its enslaving law. When you make a mistake, the Idol distains all your past efforts to adhere to its standards. The liberating law of karis, however, appreciates your efforts and offers you mercy when you fail. This mercy is based on the freedom that we have as beloved children who are encouraged to confidently explore their relationship with their Father as they engage with reality. We are expected to make mistakes in the process. With mercy and kindness, God trains us to be trustworthy so that we can co-labor with Him as He works to fulfill His desires for us and for those around us.⁴

2. Freedom is what kidnapped slaves are seeking

Our True Self is seeking our help. It is like a kidnapped member of the community that is uncared for and forced by the Idol Self to serve misorientation. Our task is to redeem that self, meet its needs, and support its development so that we might present ourselves to God whole, complete, and lacking nothing. In first century Rome, slaves, wives, and the poor were not free to change the circumstances of their lives, and yet they could envision a life of freedom. We have all been slaves to the law of misorientation, but now, as citizens living under the law of liberty through Christ, we have freedom, and we also have the resources and the responsibility to change our lives.

3. Mercy is self-confidence in action

When we feel the need to judge because something threatens us, we can choose instead to trust God for our welfare and offer mercy. Mercy triumphs over judgment.⁵ It is the law of Jesus in the court of freedom and is the opposite of self-hate. Mercy flows out of the internal wealth and freedom that our salvation in Jesus provides. We can offer mercy to others because we are confident in the mercy of our Lord. As citizens of the kingdom of God, we are free to go about our own business without the fear of failure or the fear of making mistakes. Under the kingdom law of karis, there is no condemnation, so we are free to make mistakes, find out what works, and then become the cause of our own beneficial outcomes, which builds more self-confidence. Unfettered by self-judgment and undeterred by the judgments of others, we are free to explore.

4. Mercy toward others

The unseen mercy that we show to ourselves is manifested in the material world by the mercy we show to others. We have compassion on our own impoverished True Self, and we take action to metaphorically feed and clothe it. When of our own free will, rather than compulsively, we extend ourselves to support the personal development of another, we reveal how well we are supporting ourselves. Mercy is an active, effortful self-extension that shows God we mean business about His mission, His priorities, and our relationship with Him. Showing mercy to our community is often difficult. It is an expression of your trust and requires courage because it costs you something. A gift is not a karis gift if it costs you nothing. Mercy is a karis gift.

5. God is united in effort and principle

We are called to be imitators of God, acting in congruence with what we know to be good, right, and fair.⁶ James reminds us that what God says, He does. He doesn't compartmentalize, believing one thing and yet doing something else. Congruence makes demons tremble; it makes their work impossible. Neither can the Idol Self operate when we are congruent. The Idol continually lives in illusions about what is good or right. It has good intentions that never translate into action, and it demands to be exempt from the law of cause and effect. The Idol is divided; there is a disconnect between what it claims to believe and how it chooses to act. God, in direct contrast, is fully congruent; He is One.

6. Abraham gave the karis gift of obedience

In obedient response to God's request, Abraham relinquished what he loved most—his son, who was his hope for the fulfillment of his search for glory. God saw in Abraham's obedience the evidence of trustworthiness. Abraham was congruent. He acted on what he believed about God, and through his choices, not through his ideas or good intentions, he became God's beloved friend. Congruence between oriented beliefs and choices builds trust in any friendship. When we make the effort to be congruent, acting on what we believe as Christians, we become God's trustworthy and beloved friend.

Our prayer might go something like this:

God of Abraham, help me become Your trustworthy friend. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider becoming God's trustworthy friend. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider becoming God's trustworthy friend*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. *(Pause)* Recognize with compassion whatever you may be experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Graciously allow your experience to rest in your awareness. You might notice that you instantly forget your thoughts or feelings. We often flush away feelings and thoughts before they can teach us. Notice if there is any tension or struggle as you *consider becoming God's trustworthy friend*. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is signaling when you *consider becoming God's trustworthy friend*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* For example, you might notice what hope, pessimism, or shame feels like in your body. You might feel nothing at all. Gently maintain awareness of whatever you are experiencing. *(Pause)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to observe those uncomfortable sensations. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider*

the possibility of becoming God's trustworthy friend. Is your experience right now comfortable, uncomfortable, or vague and slippery? Just observe. (Pause) What do you believe when you consider becoming God's trustworthy friend? What story do you want to tell? (Pause) Are you, perhaps like Abraham, afraid of loss? Observe your experience as just information, and breathe. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Heal

As you breathe, repeat the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore friendship with God.
- Welcome the Holy Spirit of truth as He reveals the realities of your faith.
- Welcome your present reality and the progress you have made.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.⁷

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As I learn to be God's trustworthy friend, I let go of the craving for power and control.
- As I learn to be God's trustworthy friend, I let go of the craving for admiration and affection.
- As I learn to be God's trustworthy friend, I let go of the craving for security and comfort.
- As I learn to be God's trustworthy friend, I let go of the craving for perfection. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

We are so grateful for this time together. Hold us in the power of our growing trustworthiness and lead us to the next step in our healing this week. Help us co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self and design, with our community and the rest of Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

*Pray for those who are organizing the NHG study. Pray that God will fulfill every one of their oriented desires for goodness and for the accomplishment of their work of faith through their can-do energy so that the name of our Lord will be glorified in them, and they will be glorified in Him.⁸

*(*Except when preparing for the Jubilee Year)*

¹ en.wikiquote.org/wiki/Alexander_Suvorov.

² www.brainyquote.com/quotes/quotes/c/cslewis100842.html.

³ James 1:23-25.

⁴ Rom. 2:4.

⁵ James 2:13.

⁶ Eph. 5:1; Proverbs 2:9.

⁷ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.

⁸ 2 Thess. 1:11.